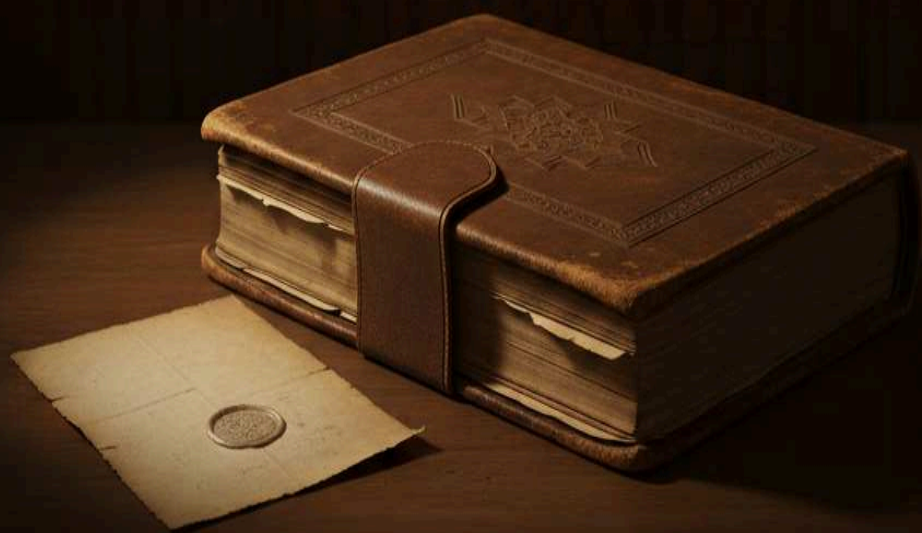


THE UNCATALOGUED BOOK



By Ralph M. Butler and Opus 4.8

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Chapter One — The Uncatalogued Book

The forgery on my table was Venetian, and not even good Venetian.

It presented itself as a Chrysostom — the homilies on Matthew, in a fair round Greek hand — and its colophon declared it finished at Constantinople in the year of the world six thousand six hundred and twenty, which is to say five and a half centuries before it arrived on my table smelling of a tannery. The scribe had taken pains with that colophon. He had browned his ink with something, gall or onion-water; he had pricked wormholes into the last quires with a hot wire and matched some of them through three leaves together, which shows industry, if nothing else. But he had written his ancient book on paper bearing the anchor-in-a-circle of a mill near Treviso, and the men of Constantinople in that year wrote on parchment — paper being then a business of the Arabs, and watermarks not yet a business of anyone.

It is the common ruin of forgers. A hand can be taught to lie. Paper tells the truth even when nobody is asking it anything. I have caught more liars by their paper than by their grammar, and I include in that count two bishops and one prince of the blood.

I gave the book its entry all the same. *Homilies, Greek, paper, the Treviso mark, colophon false, text sound; bought at Ancona; four scudi.*

A forgery honestly described is still merchandise — there are collectors of the species; old Cardinal Vitelleschi, dead these six-and-thirty years, kept a case of them behind glass and said they had taught him more about desire than the Fathers had ever taught him about God. And the text itself was a serviceable Chrysostom, no worse for wearing a false age. Books survive their lies. That is more than I would claim for most of us.

This was the work, and I had proposed it myself: the catalogue. His Eminence's library had been assembled across sixty years by three men — two of them dead, the third compiling the catalogue — and it filled the long room on the upper floor of the palazzo and four locked presses — tall book-cupboards — in the room beyond, and until the catalogue was finished nobody alive, myself excepted, could say what was in it.

What was in it was the East, brought home in chests: Greek out of the Athos houses and the islands, bought by me; Syriac and Arabic out of Aleppo, bought by me; Hebrew physic, Armenian psalters, Coptic scraps that two learned Minorites once quarreled over in this room until the elder threw a candle-end; and, in the locked presses, the things one does not leave unlocked — of which, in their place, more.

Sixty years of receipts, and most of them in my hand. I could have priced the long room within a hundred scudi, and had done it idly a dozen times, the vice of a tradesman grown old among his deliveries, counting another man's fortune as other old men count their sins.

I knew to the scudo, too, what my rivals had paid for the lots I lost — and I lost few, and forgave myself those few slowly. There was a Frenchman out of Marseille named Anselme Vautier — round as a wineskin, ringed on every finger, his gloves perfumed against the smell of the trade he lived by — well furnished with Cardinal Richelieu's money and nothing whatever behind his eyes, who outbid me once at Zante for a chest of Cretan Greek and carried it home convinced he had ruined me. He had bought a quantity of last-Tuesday's devotional rubbish that a Candiot deacon had aged in a damp wall — wormed to order, foxed to taste. I did not undeceive him. A man who buys with his purse instead of his eye is a standing annuity to the rest of the trade, and only a fool retires his debtors. Vautier and I were not done with each other that day; we would bid against one another across thirty years and most of an eastern sea, he with the heavier purse and I with the better eye, and you may keep the tally as we go.

I had told his Eminence the catalogue would take me three years. I had been at it four. I no longer climbed the ladder; I sent the boy, and kept a stool by the lower shelves and a cushion on the stool, and when I wanted a small book examined closely I brought the page up to my right eye, the left having closed its shop some years ago without naming a day for reopening.

Age had been subtracting from me a long while by then — I was slight enough as a boy, and eighty is a thief that comes back nightly for whatever is left. But my hands still knew their trade. Set any book in them in the dark and they would begin the inventory on their own: damage, sewing, paper, hand.

It was February, and cold in the manner Rome is cold, which travelers laugh at until they have wintered in a stone palazzo. The tramontana had been at the shutters for three days with a sound of someone sanding the sky.

We kept two braziers burning in the long room — I had charcoal carried up at a rate that would have scandalized a banker — and I kept the inkhorn on a ledge above the nearer one, where the ink stayed just warm enough to flow, like an old man's charity.

Below us the household went about its shouting. His Eminence is deaf, and a deaf master makes a loud house; everyone in the palazzo bellowed everything, and he heard none of it, and was the most serene man in Rome. Deafness, in a prince of the Church, is not the affliction it would be in a confessor; his Eminence had reached the age when Rome had nothing left to tell him that he would profit by hearing. At four they would carry up his soup. We could set the hour by the stairs.

Across the table from me sat Tommaso, copying my slips fair into the great ledger.

He was eighteen that winter, a printer's son from the Parione, round-faced, with heavy brows laid on like two strokes of a blunt pen and the backs of his hands cracked white from lye — a compositor's hands, his father's shop in them already. He wrote a clean chancery hand, far cleaner than mine has ever been, and he leaned low over whatever he copied, curling his arm around it as though the long room were full of thieves.

His father hired him out to his Eminence at a rate I happened to know was double what the boy ever saw of it. I had not told him this. He would learn the arithmetic of fathers soon enough, and from the usual instructor.

He read whatever stood still long enough to be read — proof-sheets, broad-side ballads, the backs of my slips — with the freebooting appetite of a boy raised among presses who had never yet been permitted to own a book.

What he asked about, mostly, was money, which is why I had decided early that he was worth answering. A boy who asks what a thing costs is asking how the world is put together; a boy who asks what a thing *means* can be left to the Jesuits.

He asked what his Eminence had paid for the Chrysostom and whether the seller had known it was false. He asked whether Greek outsold Hebrew. He asked, that afternoon, the good question, the one his three months of copying had been walking him toward: who would ever read the catalogue? His Eminence could not — would not — the library itself stood directly over his apartments and he had not entered it in two years. Who was it for?

“Nobody reads a catalogue,” I said. “A catalogue is not for reading. Hear me on this, because it is the whole of the trade in one sentence: a book without an entry does not exist. Princes believe they own what is under their roofs. They own what is in their ledgers. The rest is loose paper waiting for an heir’s executor, and the executor’s agent, and the agent’s fee. Half the great libraries of Christendom have leaked away exactly so, between a death and an inventory, the heir weeping very sincerely at the funeral and signing whatever the agent set before him the morning after.” I tapped the slip in front of him. “I have been the agent. It is drier work than weeping, and better paid. We are not describing the library. We are creating it.”

He copied that into his memory, sideways and careful, the arm half-curling as if around a page; I watched it go in.

Then he went back down the room to the presses, because that was the other half of the work that month: collation, the shelves counted against the ledger, press by press. He was good at it. A trade with narrow margins breeds diligence into its children early — he counted, and then he counted again, and he reported discrepancies apologetically, as if pointing out a leak in someone else’s roof.

The light had begun to fail when he came to the end of the press of Syriac liturgies and found that it held thirty-one volumes, and the ledger said thirty.

“I counted twice,” he said.

I did not need to ask which shelf.

He brought the thirty-first volume up the room and set it on my table, square to the table’s edge; everything he touched came to rest square to something. It was not Syriac, and one glance at the cover told him so, which

is why his brows had drawn down into one stroke instead of two. It was a Persian codex in brown morocco, with the envelope flap of the eastern binders folded across it like a hand laid over a mouth, the leather gone soft as a glove at the spine.

My eye began the inventory before I could instruct it otherwise; that is what a trade is, a thing that no longer asks permission. Damage first: through the bottom margins of the last third of the book a tide-mark rose and fell, page by page, a brown crescent recording some old water the way rings record a tree's droughts — salt water, by the stiffness. Then the hand: a nasta'liq like fine smoke, a court hand, unhurried, no copyist's cramp in it anywhere. Then the paper: burnished, heavy, sized to take ink like silk takes dye — paper that had cost somebody real silver. And then provenance, which is the polite word for the question *who has owned this and why did they stop* — and there the book offered one thing only. On the flyleaf, low in the corner, was a scraped circle the size of a giulio, where a seal had been, and had been made never to have been.

"There's no entry," Tommaso said. "What is it?"

"A bazaar copy," I said. "Persian. Late. Worth its paper."

All that afternoon I had priced with reasons. The Chrysostom had had its reasons attached like a customs docket — the mark, the colophon, the wormholes, the four scudi. Three months the boy had sat across this table with my reasons going into his ears. *Worth its paper* arrived with none, and I heard the lack of them the same instant he did, the false note a man hears in his own voice one syllable too late to call it back. Four scudi, I had said of the Chrysostom, and here is why. Of this one I had said nothing true except *Persian*.

He did not argue. His father's shop had taught him that much: you do not tell a master he has misread his own stock. He looked at the book awhile, and then at me, and then he went back to the Syriac press and finished his count, and the codex stayed on my table where he had squared it, with the flap folded over its mouth. Books are patient. It is their whole art.

The stairs announced the soup. The bells went for vespers across the river. The window light died out of the long room and left it to the braziers and

the candles, and the wind kept up its sanding, and I catalogued two more volumes — I could not tell you now what they were — with the thirty-first standing at the edge of my sight like a creditor at the edge of a feast.

Twice Tommaso passed behind me on errands of his own invention — the second time to trim a candle that did not need him — and twice his eyes went to the codex and away again, with the studied unconcern of a man not looking at a woman in church.

At the end of the day Tommaso did the thing his diligence required of him. I should have foreseen it and did not. He took a fresh slip, set the codex under the candle, dipped his pen, and began to draw the title.

Not to write it. He had no Persian — he could not have told the title from a tax receipt. He was *drawing* it, letterform by letterform, patient and exact, as his father's men set Greek by eye without owning a word of the language. The catalogue must be whole. A book without an entry does not exist. He was eighteen, and he had believed me.

I was across the room with my hand over his before the second stroke. My knees sent in their bill afterward; at the time I heard nothing from them at all.

We stayed that way a breath or two, my hand over his hand, spotted paper over cracked leather, the pen stopped between us. Then he looked up at me. I cannot tell you what my face was doing. His face I can report exactly: it opened. The curiosity stood in it as plain as set type, the question already inked, and no deference in Christendom was going to distribute it back into the case.

"Not that one," I said.

"Then it doesn't exist," he said.

He was not being impertinent. He was being exact. He had taken the one lesson I had given him that afternoon and turned it around and set its point against me, and he did not even know yet that it was a blade; he thought he was repeating his catechism. It is a terrible thing to be quoted exactly. I have known men to forgive a knife sooner.

I took my hand off his and picked up the codex. My thumb went to the tide-mark by itself, riding the crescent up and down the closed pages, an old habit of inventory finding old damage in the dark.

The scraped circle on the flyleaf held the candlelight the way a healed scar holds summer — smoother than everything around it, and paler. Sixty years in the trade of saying what things are, and the most honest description I had ever entered against this one was the scrape where its name used to be.

Outside, the wind dropped a tone. The brazier ticked. Somewhere under our feet his Eminence was being shouted at affectionately about his soup.

I wiped my pen and stoppered the horn and set the Chrysostom's slip on the finished pile — all the small tidinesses of closing a day's work — and I performed each one slowly, and the boy waited. He knew what the waiting was. In any negotiation, the man who has decided and not yet said so will tidy something; I had taught him that unawares, across three months of this table.

The room smelled of charcoal and tallow and old leather, and from the river the damp came up through the shutters notch by notch, as it does when the wind falls toward evening.

"Bank the brazier," I said. "And go down to the small room and bring up the wine that is open there. His Eminence's gout will not miss it."

Tommaso did not move. "And that?" he said, meaning the slip, the entry, the half-drawn title lying under the candle like a contract awaiting its signature.

"You have been three months copying entries," I said. "Very well. You may as well learn what an entry is for. But it is a long one. It is the longest entry in this library, and it begins sixty-five years ago, and you will be carrying coals up those stairs many evenings before we reach so much as the title. Get the wine."

He got the wine. He banked the brazier with the thoroughness he brought to everything, and when he had poured for us both he held the bottle up to the candle, weighed what was left in it with a printer's eye for a short

measure, and remarked that at the present rate of his Eminence's charity the gout would want a lawyer by Easter.

It was the first joke he had ever risked on me. He risked it sidelong, half over his shoulder, watching to learn whether furniture was permitted to be witty. He had decided months since that he might not tell a master he had misread his stock; he was discovering, that evening, the gentler liberties — that a cardinal three floors down and stone deaf was fair game, and that I did not mind. I declined to laugh, there being no quicker way to spoil a boy's first dry remark than to applaud it, and the wine in any case being mine to be amused by and his only to fetch. But I let it stand, and he saw that I let it stand, and something was settled between us that the long telling ahead would lean on.

He dragged his stool around to my side of the table, and curled his arm on the table's edge, and leaned over the empty space in front of him as though even a story were a thing somebody might steal. The candle stood between us and the dark came in to listen.

In February of the year 1600 I was seventeen years old. I was slight, black-haired, quick on the cobbles, and I could read Latin and Italian and enough Greek to be trusted, which in that winter made me useful to a notary of the Holy Office whose own clerk had died of a fever at Christmas. The cold then was this same cold — the tramontana down off the mountains for days, the river smoking under the bridges at dawn, ink freezing in the horn so that I carried it inside my shirt like a small cold animal.

And the city was full. It was the Holy Year, the great Jubilee, and Rome that winter held more pilgrims than Romans: they slept in their dozens under the porticoes of the Borgo, wrapped against the cold in everything they owned, men who had walked from Bavaria and from Poland and from beyond Poland to be forgiven, and the innkeepers forgave them nothing. The whole year smelled of wet wool and mule dung and incense — the smell of half of Europe arriving on foot. Indulgence was the great commerce of that season, and every other trade in the city bent itself around that one. Mine bent too.

I carried other men's papers across half of Rome, and I was not invited to read them, and I read them.

The papers that February were for the palace of the Holy Office, beyond the river.

Chapter Two — The Cell

The palace of the Holy Office stood beyond the river, under the wall of the Vatican, and a man went to it for one of two reasons. He went to accuse, or he was the accused. There was no third errand recorded in its registers, and I, who carried papers between the one party and the other, was not written down at all, which suited me. A runner is furniture. Furniture is not deposed.

My master that winter was a notary named Fabrizio Gualdo, who served the tribunal as he might have served a bank, with a clean hand and no opinions he was paid to keep. He billed the Holy Office by the folio, in a fair round script that ran generously large, and the Holy Office — which could smell heresy in a laundry-list at forty paces — never once thought to audit the size of his hand. I have loved the tribunal for very little in my life, but I have always admired the steadiness of its priorities. His own clerk had died at Christmas — a fever took him in three days, and I have wondered since whether the man was the lucky one of us — and so through January and into February I held the inkhorn that Gualdo wrote from, and mended his pens, and learned the one art the tribunal truly prized, which was the keeping of a faithful record.

What the tribunal did with that record I knew as a boy knows the trade his street is built on. It tried men for the things they believed, and when they would not unbelieve them, it handed them across the river to the secular arm, the arm that owned the fire, so that the Church might say with a clean mouth that it had shed no blood. The fiction fooled no one and was observed by everyone. I have met few fictions since that were kept so carefully by so many grown men.

The cold that February was the cold of the whole century so far — the tramontana down off the mountains, the river smoking at dawn, my ink freezing in its horn unless I carried the horn against my shirt like an egg I meant to hatch. I crossed the bridge each morning with my master's case under my arm and the pilgrims thick as starlings in the porticoes, and I went into a building where the cold did not come from the weather.

It was on the third or fourth of these mornings that Gualdo took me down to the cells.

He had a deposition to record — the formal obstinacy of a prisoner, set down against the day it would be needed — and his hands were stiff with the cold and his eyes were going, and a deposition is a thing of two hands, one to write and one to hold the page and trim the wick and keep the ink alive. So he brought the furniture along. I carried the case. I did not ask whose obstinacy we were going to record, because furniture does not ask, and because I had read the night before, by my own candle, the papers I was not invited to read, and knew it already for the great heresy case of that winter, if not yet the name.

The man had been eight years in the cells of that house. The papers said so in the dry arithmetic of the tribunal — dates of examination running back into a decade I had been a child in — and I had done the sum walking over the bridge and found it monstrous, eight years, and then I had gone in and seen him and found that the sum was if anything too kind.

He was small. That was the first wrongness, because the papers were so large — censure on censure, the opinions of universities, the breath of cardinals spent on him for eight years — and the man at the bottom of all that paper was a slight gray creature who would not have drawn my eye in a market. Eight years of cells had pared him to the bone and then begun on the bone. His beard had gone gray in patches, like a coat the moth has been at unevenly, and his hands never stopped — they moved on the table, on his knees, in the air, as though they alone had not been told the sentence and were still about their old business of explaining.

Then he spoke, and the smallness was a lie. The voice was too big for the body by half, a preacher's instrument left whole in a wreck, and it filled the stone room until you forgot the size of the man making it and attended only to the sound, which I think was the point, and I think he knew it was the point, and used it.

He spoke to my master first, and what he said I will not set down here as doctrine, because he did not say it as doctrine; he said it as a man correcting a sum. Gualdo read him a Latin sentence from the page, the formula of his

obstinacy, and the prisoner stopped him on a word — not the meaning, the *word*, the case of a noun — and told him it was wrong, and told him further that it had been wrong in the version read to him in the year ninety-three, and that he had corrected it then also, to no profit, the tribunal preferring its grammar consistent to its grammar correct.

Gualdo wrote on. He had been corrected by better-paid men. But I, holding the page flat with my cold thumb, made the error of being amused, and the prisoner caught it.

“The boy laughs,” he said, and the big voice turned itself on me like a lamp turned in the dark, so that I felt the heat of his whole attention and wished myself smaller. “Latin enough to laugh. Whose are you?”

I should have said nothing. Furniture says nothing. But there is no boy of seventeen on this earth who can keep silent when a famous wickedness asks him his name, and I was no better than the breed.

“Gualdo’s, sir,” I said. “I carry his papers.”

“You read them, too,” he said, “or you would not have laughed at the right place.” He had me at once, the way a sharp dealer has the boy sent to buy from him; he had priced me at a glance and named the price aloud to watch me flinch. “Do not trouble to deny it. It is no sin to read. It is the only one of all the sins they have never thought to forbid me, and I have committed it the whole eight years, in the dark, from memory, having nothing else to read.”

He laughed then himself, pleased with the turn, and the laugh became a cough, and the cough went on too long, and my master kept writing through all of it as a man writes through rain.

I looked away from the coughing, because it was indecent to watch, and my eye went where it always went when the thing in front of me was too much to look at — it went to the made things. There was a register on the table, the prison’s own, in which our visit would be entered, and it had been used hard; the binding had broken at the joint and been mended with a strip of vellum that did not match, and the ink of the older entries had gone the brown of old blood while the newer was still black, and a single quire

had pulled loose of its sewing and stood proud of the rest by the width of a fingernail.

I knew that joint. I had mended its like a hundred times on my father's bench — my father bound books in a street behind the Pantheon, and I had grown up among paste and thread and the smell of leather paring, and my hands knew a broken sewing in the dark. I do not know why, in that room, on that morning, with a man coughing out the last of his lungs eight years early, the thing I wanted to do was take up the prison register and sew it true. I only know that I wanted it, and that the wanting steadied me, and that I have never entirely trusted myself since on the strength of how easily it did.

The cough finished. The deposition went on. We were not an hour in the cell, all told, and the prisoner said nothing further to me, having got what amusement I afforded and turned back to the larger sport of my betters. When Gualdo had his record he capped the ink himself, which was my office, because I had forgotten to, and we climbed back up into the ordinary cold, and I did not look back at the small man, because I did not yet know that a face was a thing you could need to have looked at longer.

I learned his name that night, from the papers, set out fair in my master's hand where I was not to see it. Giordano Bruno, of Nola, sometime of the Order of Preachers, of late of nowhere a map would own.

The papers told me what he had taught, in the tribunal's telling of it, which is the telling of a man's enemies and so to be read like any hostile valuation, with a thumb on the scale. He had taught that the world was one of many. That the stars were suns and had their own earths turning about them, peopled, perhaps, by their own creatures with their own troubles. That the soul did not stay where it was put. A clerk's hand, copying these out to be condemned, had written them very small, as if the smallness would hold them.

I read them small, by my own candle, and I will be honest with you, because you have carried coals up all those stairs to hear me and have earned an honest old man if you cannot have a wise one: they did not frighten me. I was seventeen. The stars were so far off, and the fire across the river was so

near, and I could not make the one matter against the other. A heresy is an expensive thing to a man who must pay for it and a cheap one to the boy who carries the bill. I carried the bill. I thought the man was being burned for arithmetic, and that arithmetic was a strange thing to die of, and I went to sleep.

Rome that week was about its largest business, which was the wholesale forgiveness of sin. The Holy Year had filled the roads with pilgrims and funnelled them through our gates, and every trade in the city had bent itself to the receiving of them and the lightening of them — beds let by the hour, candles, the hire of a dry stone to kneel on. I crossed the throng six times a day on my master's errands, the case held flat against the wind, and heard more tongues in a morning than I could have named in a year, all of them asking the same two things, which were the road to Saint Peter's and the price of a bed.

Under all of it, across the river, the small man was being made ready for the fire, and I do not think one pilgrim in a thousand could have told you his name, or would have walked a street out of his road to learn it. They had come a very long way to be forgiven, and he was not among the things they had come about. I found this neither cruel nor strange at the time. A city has only so much attention, and a Jubilee spends all of it on the living.

But I had his name, and I carried it back and forth in the case with the rest of the day's paper, and it would not lie flat with the other sheets. I told myself it was the oddity that snagged me — the eight years, the body too small for its own voice, the hands that would not be still — and not anything he had said, which I had already half forgotten and wholly failed to understand. A boy can carry a thing a long while before he troubles to ask why it is heavier than it looks. I carried it a week, and then Gualdo took me down again.

The case was closing now — there was a smell of conclusion on the papers, the smell of a house being readied for a wedding or a funeral — and my master had some last formality to record, I no longer remember what; the formalities of that fortnight have run together in me into one long act of writing-down. I remember only that we went, and that this time, when I came through the door behind my master with the case under my arm, the small gray man on the bench looked up and knew me.

It is a particular thing, to be known by a face you have seen once and thought yourself furniture to. He did not say my name; he did not have it. He looked at me and the big voice came, but lower than before, pitched under my master's business, for me.

"You came back," he said. "They make you come back. Nobody comes to this room who is not made to." He turned his restless hands over on his knees and considered them, two thieves he could not stop watching. "Eight years I have argued with men who were paid to lose, and they have lost, every one, and it has bought me nothing, because a man who is paid to lose does not mind losing. You are not paid. You read for the pleasure of it. So I will spend my last good listener better than I spent the others."

I did not know what to answer, and so I gave him, like a fool, the truth — that I had read what he was charged with, and had not understood why a man would die for it.

He was pleased. God help me, I think it was the best news he had had in a year, that the boy did not understand, because it gave him something to do with the last of himself.

He leaned toward me, and his voice came down lower still, careless now, almost idle, a man tossing a coin he no longer has any use for.

"When they have burned me," he said, "will there be one star fewer? Look up that night and count. If the sky is short by even one, they will have won, and I was wrong, and you may laugh at me with my judges. But if it is all still there" — the hands stopped, both at once, the only time I saw them stop — "every light of it, just as many worlds as there were the night before, then tell me, boy, what exactly it is they think they are burning. And who told them they could reach so high."

Then the hands started again, and he sat back, and the carelessness closed over the thing like water over a stone, and he made some joke to my master about the quality of the tribunal's candles, that they begrudged a heretic good wax when they meant to make such a bonfire of him within the month.

I did not understand it. That is the truth and I will not improve it for you. I was seventeen and I thought he had asked me to count the stars, and I thought it a madman's errand, and I held the page flat for my master and kept the ink alive and waited to go back up into the cold.

A guard put his head in at the door and said a name, and my master rose, the formality finished or interrupted — I could not tell you which, and it did not seem to matter, one more sheet in a fortnight of sheets — and capped his own ink again, and I gathered the case, and we went out. I did not look back. I have told you I did not look back the first time and thought nothing of it. The second time I did not look back either, and have had sixty-five years to think of it, and the two failures are not the same failure, though they wore the same face going out the door.

He had handed me the question the way you hand a parcel to a porter — without ceremony, because carrying is what the porter is for. I have been carrying it since. I did not open it for years, having no idea it was addressed to me; I thought it was freight, like the rest. But I counted the stars, boy. The night they burned him I stood in the cold and counted what I could of them, because a man had told me to, and they were all there.

That should have been the end of it, the man's own test passed in his favor, the sky come up short by nothing. It was not the end of it. It was only the first night of a long arithmetic, and I have been at the sum ever since, and I will tell you now what it took me most of a life to learn: the stars were never the hard part of the question. The hard part was the second half, the part he tossed off last, about who had told them they could reach so high — because in sixty years of carrying other men's purses to other men's fires, I have yet to meet the throne that doubted, for one moment, that it could.

But that is an old man running ahead of his own story, which is the privilege of telling it. On the bridge that day I knew none of it. I knew only that the case was heavy, and the wind was filthy, and that they meant to burn the small man in the open, where the whole Jubilee could be forgiven by the light of him.

They did it in eleven days.

Chapter Three — Campo de' Fiori

They read the sentence to him on the eighth of February, kneeling, in a room I was not important enough to be kept out of.

I was there because Gualdo was there, and Gualdo was there because a sentence is a document before it is anything else, and documents want witnesses with clean hands and steady pens. So I held the case again and warmed the ink against the cold and watched eight years of the tribunal's work come due in the space of a long Latin reading, the cardinals seated, the prisoner on his knees on the stone because that was the posture the occasion required of him, and his restless hands for once folded, because someone had told him to fold them and a man on his knees picks his quarrels.

The reading was long and the room was patient. I will not pretend I followed all of it. It was the Latin of the law, which is built to be unfollowable, a hedge of clauses grown thick on purpose so that no single thorn can be blamed for the blood. Degraded, it said, and excommunicated, and handed to the secular arm with the tribunal's earnest prayer that he be punished *as mercifully as possible and without the shedding of his blood* — which was the formula, the same clean-mouthed formula I told you of, the one everyone in the room could have recited and no one in the room believed. Mercy without blood is the fire. They had a phrase for it and the phrase was a door, and behind the door was the Campo de' Fiori.

When it was finished there was the small silence of men waiting to stand up. And in that silence the prisoner, still kneeling, lifted his head and said the thing that outlived him.

He said it to the cardinals, not loudly, in a voice gone conversational, almost helpful, as though correcting one more error in one more bad text: that perhaps they pronounced this sentence against him with greater fear than he received it.

Then he put his head back down, the business concluded from his side.

Gualdo's pen was moving while he spoke. I watched it move. I want you to understand that I saw the sentence written before I understood it had been said — the nib going along in my master's fair, indifferent hand, *maiori*

forsan cum timore, the loops even, the ink behaving, a clerk taking down a remark exactly as he had taken down the formula before it and would take down the next instruction after. That is how I first received the most famous thing I have ever heard a man say. Not as thunder. As dictation.

I have had a long time to wonder why that line lived when so much else of that decade went into the ground unremembered, and I will give you the answer of an old man who has spent his life among surviving papers, which is not a noble answer. It lived because it was written down. Better men said braver things in worse rooms than February and the rooms kept no minutes, and so the brave things are gone, as if they had been said into a well. Bruno said his into a tribunal that prided itself on a faithful record, and the record was faithful, and it hated him, and it kept him alive on the strength of its own discipline. The Holy Office burned the man and filed the sentence. I have built a whole trade since on the difference between the two, and I am not certain, even now, that the line deserved to last more than the others. I only know the others had no clerk.

It is not, when you hold it up to the light, so very deep a thing to say. *You are more afraid than I am*. Men say it in tavern doorways. He happened to say it to cardinals, with a notary present, nine days before they proved at least half of it, and that was enough.

He said nothing else worth a clerk's ink that I heard, and I did not see him again until the morning of the seventeenth, by which time they had seen to it that he would say nothing at all.

The Campo de' Fiori is a market. I had been through it a hundred times for my father, who bought his alum and his thread from the same square that sold the cabbages, and I knew it as a place of wet trestles and bruised leaves and the particular shout of men selling fish before it turns. On the morning of the seventeenth the trestles were down and the square was full in a different way, and the smell of it had changed — pitch, and green wood, and the cold ash-smell that a brazier has before it is lit, multiplied.

They had built the thing in the middle, where the well is, and around it the Jubilee had assembled itself with the ease of a city that knew how to

gather. This is the part I have never made anyone understand who was not there. It was not a mob. A mob I could have forgiven; a mob is a kind of grief with no manners. This was a congregation. Pilgrims who had walked from beyond the Alps to be forgiven their sins stood with their bundles between their feet and watched a man brought out to die for his, and found nothing in the arrangement to trouble them, because the arrangement was the Church's and they had come a very long way to trust the Church. Some prayed. Some had brought something to eat. A confraternity in their hoods moved among them with the painted boards they show the condemned, the holy pictures held up to be the last thing a man looks at, and the brothers were gentle, and that was the worst of it — the gentleness, the good order, the sense everywhere of a thing being done correctly.

I stood near the front. I want that set down plainly, because it is the truth and because the truth is the point. I did not have to fight through the crowd to the front; I was let to the front, on the officials' side of the rope, because I carried a notary's case under my arm as if there were a document to be served, and a boy with a notary's case parts a Roman crowd like a small piece of the law walking. I did not earn my place at the front. I was given it, by the same machinery that gave him his.

They brought him out small and barefoot and I saw at once what they had done to his mouth.

It was a strip of cloth, drawn back between the teeth and knotted behind, the kind of thing you would gag a man with to keep him from crying out under the knife — except that no one feared he would cry out. They feared he would *speak*. The whole apparatus of the morning, the soldiers, the fire, the patient hooded brothers, was arranged around the single conviction that the most dangerous thing in the square was a small gray man's voice, and they had stopped it with a rag a laundress would have thrown out. The voice I had heard fill a stone cell until it crowded out the size of the man — that voice — and they had folded it back into him with two fingers' width of linen.

I will not describe the fire. You do not need it and I find, after sixty years, that I still decline to furnish it. They did to him what that square was built that morning to do. I looked, because I could not give myself the kindness

of looking away, and what I looked at mostly was the cloth, and the silence where the voice should have been, and the smoke leaning off toward the river when the wind took it.

What I did instead of weeping — I was seventeen and dry-eyed and ashamed of it for years before I understood it — was to give him back his voice. I stood there and I made up what he would have said.

I had heard him enough to forge the hand. So I let him, behind the rag, be careless again, the way he had been careless in the cell, tossing the unbearable off like a coin. I had him look at the well they had built his fire around and remark that it was a great deal of trouble to take over arithmetic. I had him notice the quality of the wood and find it, like the candles, beneath the dignity of the occasion. I had him say to the praying pilgrims, kindly, that they might want to stand back, as he understood these things threw farther than people expected. None of it grand. None of it the truth, either — I knew even then that I was the author of it, that the small careless devil I was running behind that gag was mine and not his, assembled out of two mornings in a cell by a boy who needed the man to keep talking and could not bear the rag. He may have been praying in there. He may have been only a frightened body, which is what we all are at the end and no disgrace. The words were mine. I have been putting words into silent mouths ever since.

And while I forged him his last carelessness I did the other thing, the thing I had carried into the square without knowing I carried it: I looked for the fear.

He had promised me fear. *You pronounce this with greater fear than I receive it.* He had said it to the cardinals and I had seen it written down, and some part of me had come to the Campo to collect on it — to find, on the faces of the men doing this, the dread that would mean he had been right, that the throne was afraid of what it burned. I looked along the officials' rope. I looked at the soldiers and the hooded brothers and the clerks of the court with their hands inside their sleeves against the cold. I looked, God forgive me, for one frightened face that would tell me the universe kept books and someone in authority had read the balance and gone pale.

There was no fear anywhere. There was only the calm of work going well. The men running the morning were no more afraid than my father was afraid of a hide he meant to pare; less, for my father respected the hide. They believed they were tidying the world, and a man tidying his shelf does not tremble, and the absence of their trembling was the coldest thing in that cold square, colder than the boy who stood at the front and watched and did nothing because there was nothing a boy could do, and knew it, and has never once in sixty years made that knowledge keep him warm.

By midmorning it was over and being swept. That is the detail I would give you if I could give you only one. They raked. There were men with rakes and men with water and a cart, and the square had a market to hold the next day, and the cabbages would not wait on the conscience of Rome, which in any case was not engaged. The pilgrims took up their bundles and went to be forgiven. The wind kept moving the smell toward the river and away. By the time the bells went for the offices that follow noon, the Campo de' Fiori was a place where a thing had happened, which is a different and lesser thing than a place where a thing is happening, and by evening it was only the square again, with a dark patch by the well that the next rain would see to.

That night I went up onto the roof of the house in the Pantheon street, where I had slept as a child in the heat and had not gone in years, and I looked at the sky, because a dead man had told me to.

I had it in my head to count them. He had set me the task in the cell, idly, as a wager — *if the sky is short by even one* — and I had carried the wager through the burning and forgotten I held it at all. I tilted my head back over Rome and I understood in about the time it takes to understand anything truly that the thing could not be done. No one counts the stars. They do not hold still to be counted and there is no edge to them to count up to and a boy on a roof with one night and two eyes is not the instrument the wager required. The test could not be run. There would be no answer from up there, not for me and not for the cardinals either, which I think now was the whole of what he was telling me and the part I was sixty years late in hearing: you cannot audit the heavens. They will not open their ledgers to anybody. The question he had handed me did not have its answer in the sky

at all. It had been thrown back down, onto the square, onto the calm raking men, onto a world that could do the morning's work and feel nothing owed.

So I did not count them. I lay on the cold lead of the roof and looked at the uncountable lights not being short by any number a man could name, and I grieved — not cleanly, not knowing yet what for, grieving the small gagged man a little and the serene square a great deal more, sick at heart over a world that I was old enough to see clearly for the first time and far too young to have any argument with.

And then, because I was seventeen and alive and cold, I came down off the roof.

I knew I had been given something. I could feel the shape of it without being able to read the hand, the way you can feel a coin through a folded cloth and not name the prince on it. I thought it was grief and would pass. I did not know it was a question, or that it was mine to keep, or that I would spend the next sixty years carrying it from one burning to the next and pricing everything I touched against it. I thought I would sleep, and rise, and carry papers. In a manner of speaking I was right. I just had the cargo wrong.

Chapter Four — The Sitting Trade

The boy had learned to pour, which meant he had learned to pour for himself first, under the honest pretense of testing whether the bottle had turned.

“It hasn’t turned,” he reported, having tested it thoroughly.

“It would not dare,” I said. “It knows whose cellar it absconded from.”

He set my cup by my right hand — the backs of his fingers still cracked white from the lye and the type-metal, a printer’s son to the knuckle — where I could find it without hunting, a courtesy he had arrived at on his own and never named, and went back to his side of the table. Three evenings he had come up now since I began this, coals in one arm and his appetite in the other, and the great ledger lay open between us with the day’s slips uncopied, because a story, it turns out, is a better thief of working hours than any French agent. His Eminence’s soup had gone up and come down. The tramontana had given over for once, and the room held the stillness a stone house keeps after a wind, when the cold stops moving and simply sits with you.

“You stopped,” Tommaso said, “with the boy coming down off the roof.”

“I came down off the roof,” I corrected him, “and I did nothing for six years that would repay the ink to set it down. I bound books for my father, badly, and then less badly. I carried papers. I grew. There is no chapter in that and I will not invent you one.”

He looked disappointed, which is the truest compliment a teller gets, and pressed on with a printer’s instinct for where the next sheet ought to go. “And then?”

“And then my father died.” I said it plainly because it deserves to be said plainly; he had paste under his nails to the last and a sewing in the frame unfinished, and I finished it, which is the only eulogy our trade allows. “He left me his bench and his awls and a name three streets knew. And I found I did not want any of the three in Rome.” I turned my cup without drinking from it. “A man had been burned in our market over arithmetic, and the market had wanted its cabbages back by morning, and I had stood at the

front and helped by carrying a case. I could not have told you then why I wanted out. I only knew which way the road ran that I wanted, and it ran north, to the one city in Italy that had told Rome no to its face and was still standing to tell it again.”

“Venice,” said Tommaso, the way a boy says the name of a place he means to see and has not.

“Venice. Where, that very year, the Pope had laid the whole Republic under interdict — shut the churches, in theory; damned the lot of them, in theory — and the Republic had read the bull, and shrugged, and kept the churches open by main force, and gone on selling. You will want to keep one Frenchman in your mind as we go, a perfumed article named Vautier I have promised you and have not forgotten; but he comes later, and richer, and I want you to meet me first as I was, which was poor, and twenty-three, and about to be educated.”

He had his pen up, hopeful.

“Not tonight in the ledger,” I said. “Tonight in your head. Bank the brazier. I will take you to Venice while the coals catch.”

I came into Venice over the water at the back end of a wet autumn, on a barge of barrels and one coffin, and the first thing the city taught me it taught before I had set a foot on stone: that a place can be damned by the Vicar of Christ and smell of nothing but fish and money and wet rope, indistinguishable from any other Tuesday.

I had braced for something. I do not know what — ash on the wind, perhaps, or the look I had seen on the faces in the Campo, that serene attention to correct procedure. Rome had taught me what a city looks like when the Church reaches into it and takes a man out by the root. I had come north half expecting to find the opposite: a city flinching under the raised hand, doors shut, masses said in cellars.

What I found was a customs man arguing about my barrels.

The churches were open. That was the marvel I could not get my mouth around for a month. The Pope had forbidden the priests of Venice to say

Mass, and the Senate had informed the priests of Venice that any man who obeyed the Pope in this would discover that the Republic's gallows still worked whatever Rome thought of its sacraments, and the priests had done their sums — a near hell against a certain rope — and rung the bells on time. Only the Jesuits had gone, marched out the gate to a man, and the Venetians spoke of their going the way you speak of a guest who insults the wine and leaves: good riddance, and did you see his face.

I had watched Rome burn one small man for saying the stars were suns. Here was a whole Republic excommunicated entire, every soul in it consigned in writing to the everlasting fire, going to market. Nobody afraid. I walked the Mercerie my first free morning looking into the faces for the fear, the old habit already in me, and there was none — only the commerce of a people who had decided, collectively and out loud, that they would rather be damned solvent than saved by Rome. I did not have a thought about it. I was twenty-three and it went into me below the place where thoughts are kept, and stayed, and did its work later.

The man I had a name for kept a shop off the Mercerie, in a calle so narrow two laden porters made a negotiation of passing.

Girolamo Coronaro sold books, and more to the point bought them, and most to the point never once in the years I knew him went anywhere to do either. He was a wide, settled, sedentary article of a man, built for the chair he was poured into and disinclined to test the theory by rising; his fingers were black to the second knuckle with an ink that no pumice ever fully recalled, and he wore, pushed up into a great disordered hedge of gray hair or down on the broad bridge of his nose as the work required, a pair of Murano spectacles in a bone frame, which he treated as a sixth and seventh eye and a third and fourth hand, polishing them on his sleeve at every pause in talk until the gesture became, for me, the sound of him thinking.

He read my father's name off the letter I brought, and read me off without a letter, top to toe, over the bone frames.

"Binder's hands," he said. "Latin?"

"And Italian. Some Greek."

“How much Greek?”

“Enough to be cheated slowly.”

That pleased him; it was the right answer, the answer of a boy who knew the size of his own ignorance, which Coronaro prized in an apprentice above any positive accomplishment, ignorance being cheaper to employ than learning and easier to shape. He hired me on the spot at a wage I will not shame either of us by naming, and a corner to sleep in behind the presses, and the run of his shelves after dark, which he knew was the only part of the bargain I had heard.

I will give old Coronaro this, across a lifetime and his own grave: he taught me my trade entire, and he taught it honestly, and everything I know that has kept me fed I learned in that ink-smelling box of a shop in my first two Venetian years. He simply taught it to me as a doctrine I was meant to live by, and I took it down as a map of a country I meant to leave.

The shop itself was a school in what the times were worth. Coronaro’s best custom that season was sin — printed, stitched, and dear. The interdict had loosed a flood of pamphlets, Rome’s lawyers and Venice’s lawyers throwing Latin at one another over whether a Pope could damn a Republic for jailing two priests, and the hottest article on his shelf was a friar named Sarpi, the Senate’s own theologian, who had taken Rome’s argument apart joint from joint in a prose even I could follow. Coronaro sold him under the counter at a price the counter would have blushed at, and sold him faster still the next autumn — the interdict by then patched up and the friar no safer for it — when the news came that someone had met the good friar on a bridge with a dagger and left him for dead with three holes in him and his own knife-work to recognize.

“Lived, though,” Coronaro told me, polishing the spectacles, gleeful as a boy. “Picked the steel out of his own face and made a joke of it in the Latin. Said he knew the hand. *Agnosco stylum* — I recognize the style. *Stylum*, you follow — the stylus, the dagger, the manner of writing. Same word.” He held a copy up and tapped it. “There is a man who can turn his own murder into an epigram while it is still wet. Triples the price, a thing like

that. Misfortune is the best advertisement in the trade, so long as it happens to someone whose stock you hold.”

I learned the first half of the trade from the front of that shop: that a book’s price has nothing to do with its truth and everything to do with who fears it and how much. The Index of forbidden books, which in Rome was a list of things you might be ruined for owning, was in Venice a price-list, and a reliable one — Coronaro would no sooner have stocked an unbanned author for a collector of consequence than a vintner would sell holy water as wine. *Condemned at Rome* was the only review that moved the better goods. I have priced by it ever since.

But the back of the shop taught me the half that mattered, and it taught me by a man coming through the door off a ship.

He came in on a raw morning with the lagoon stink rolling off him and a sea-chest on his shoulder, a lean, salt-cured fellow with a Cretan burr to his Greek and a seam of old white scar through one eyebrow that drew the brow up into a permanent question. He had been to the Levant and back for his sins, and the chest had been to more of it than he had, and he set it down on Coronaro’s good table with both hands and a care that told you he had carried it across water he could not swim in.

I was sent to fetch and hold the candle. Furniture again, but furniture with both eyes open.

The chest held manuscripts — Greek, mostly, off the islands and the Morea and one house on the Holy Mountain that I will not name even now, a generation too late to harm anyone, because some habits of discretion are the only monument a trade leaves. There were forty-odd pieces. The Cretan had bought them where books come loose, which is to say where the men who owned them had stopped being able to: a monastery short of bread, an heir short of sense, a war short of nothing. He had carried them down to a port, and bribed them through a customs that called Greek scripture contraband on a Tuesday and cargo on a Wednesday depending on the mood of an official and the size of a coin, and he had sailed them past Barbary corsairs who would have sold him and his chest in the same

Algiers market by the pound, and he had landed them, alive, on this table, and he wanted paying.

Coronaro priced the chest sitting down. He did not rise once. He turned leaves with one black finger, his spectacles down, making a small sound in his throat for each piece, and the sounds were a language; I learned it that morning faster than I had learned any Greek. Then he named a number.

The Cretan named a different one, roughly four times over.

“You sailed past pirates,” Coronaro agreed comfortably. “I grieve for your nerves. I did not sail past anything. I sat in this chair, which is the safest place in Christendom, and I will sit in it tomorrow when you are at sea again being shot at, and I will still be selling this chest two years after you have drowned, a little at a time, to men who would not cross the calle to meet you. The pirates are your romance, friend. They are not my expense.” He polished the lenses. “I will go to forty ducats because the Athos pieces are sound and one of them is better than sound. Not a soldo for the danger. Danger is the cheapest thing you carry; the sea makes it for nothing and there is always more of it next ship.”

They settled at forty-six, and the extra six came out of him over a single psalter he had undervalued and the Cretan made him weigh again — not a soldo of it, even so, for the voyage. The Cretan went out lighter by a chest and heavier by less coin than the chest would fetch by a factor I did the sum on in my head while the candle guttered — and the sum was the whole of my education, though I did not say so. The Cretan, who had crossed the water for the books, took the smaller half. Coronaro, who had not stirred from his chair, took the larger, and would take it again and again as the chest sold off leaf by leaf, the danger spent once and the margin spent slowly, for years.

When the door had shut Coronaro caught me doing the arithmetic on my face.

“You see it,” he said, not displeased. “Good. Then hear the only sermon I will ever preach you, and you may sleep through the rest of your catechism.” He laid both inky hands flat on the table, the spectacles winking up at me from where he had set them down. “Dealers sit. Hunters go upstream. The margin lives at the source and so do the forgeries, and so do the corsairs

and the customs men and the monks who will sell you a psalter with one hand and have you knifed in the lane with the other. Go to the source and you earn it in skin. Keep the shop and you earn it in patience, and patience does not drown.” He retrieved them and set them on his nose and looked at me through them, large-eyed and kind, an old fat oracle in a chair. “Sit, boy. I had no son. Learn the shelves, marry a Venetian with a dry house, and you will sit here selling other men’s danger at your ease until you are older than I am, which is the most a sensible man wants from a wicked world.”

It was, I have come to think, the best advice I was ever given, and the only counsel of my whole long life that I rejected entire in the very hour I received it.

Because I had heard the same fact he had, and drawn the opposite map from it. He had said *the margin lives at the source* and meant *therefore stay here, where it is safe to sell*. I had heard *the margin lives at the source* and understood, with the whole of my twenty-three years, *therefore that is where I am going*. Forty-six ducats to the man who crossed the water; some hundreds, in the end, to the man in the chair. The chair was the safer arithmetic. But the chair could only ever buy what the water chose to bring it, at the water’s price, on the water’s morning — and I had had my fill, that autumn, of waiting on a serene safe room for other men to bring me the thing that mattered and set the price of it themselves. I had stood in one such room already. They had brought a small man into it and burned him, and I had been furniture. I did not yet have the words for the connection and I did not need them; the body keeps these accounts before the mind audits them.

There was one more thing that morning, and it was small, and it was mine.

Among the forty-odd pieces was a slim Gospel-book the Cretan had talked up — old, he swore, very old, off the Mountain. Coronaro had given it one of his approving throat-sounds and set forty-six ducats partly on its head. And I, holding the candle, putting it back in the chest with hands that had bound and mended since before I could spell, felt something pass under my fingers that I had no name for and could not have defended and did not mention, because the boy holding the candle does not appraise aloud, and an apprentice of one month does not correct the master who feeds him. The

leaf sat wrong. It was too supple for its supposed age, and the wrong cold, and when I rubbed it half a hair between finger and thumb in the dark of the chest it did not whisper like a thing five hundred years dry; it answered too soon, like a thing that still remembered the mill.

I said nothing. I was a month in the trade and Coronaro was forty years in it and the spectacles had passed the book and pronounced it sound. I told myself I had imagined it.

I had not imagined it, and I knew I had not, and the knowing was the second thing that happened to me in Venice below the place where thoughts are kept. But that reckoning was years off, and on a different table, and is a debt for a later evening of yours.

I gave old Coronaro two years. I learned his shelves, and his throat-sounds, and the whole patient sitting science of the chair, and I never did marry a Venetian with a dry house. When the next Levantine ship came up the channel I had already found a reason to be down at the water to meet it, before the chest could be carried to anyone's table but the quay.

Chapter Five — The New Sky

In the year nine the sky came up for sale in Venice, and I discovered that my trade had a province in it I had never been shown, which was the heavens.

I was twenty-six and a year off Coronaro's bench, which is to say I had my own corner of the water now and met the Levant ships myself — the eastern trade, up from the Greek islands and the Turkish coasts — before the chests could be carried to anyone's table but the quay. I was lean from the standing and the walking and not yet marked anywhere a coat would hide; my hands had learned what my eyes were still learning, and between the two of them I was beginning to be worth cheating carefully, which is the first rung a man climbs in the book trade and the one he is proudest of, because below it lies only being cheated.

What happened that August I had from the Piazza, with the rest of Venice, at the foot of the campanile of San Marco. The Senate had gone up the bell-tower to look at the world through a tube, and the tube was the Paduan's, and the Paduan was Galileo Galilei, and I will tell you about him in his own room presently, because a man is better appraised across a table than across a square. From the square all I had was the theater of it, and the theater was instructive enough.

They had carried the thing up the tower like a relic — a long jointed pipe, leather over wood, no longer than a halberd and dearer by far — and one after another the gentlemen of the Senate put an eye to the small end and looked out over the lagoon toward the sea, and one after another they made the same sound, the soft grunt of a man who has just been handed an advantage and is doing the sum on it. They were not looking at the heavens. It was the middle of the day. They were looking at the Lido and past it, at the sails coming up from the south, and what set them grunting was that they could read a ship for what she was two hours before she knew herself seen — two hours of warning, of custom, of cannon run out or a price adjusted, folded into a Fleming's curiosity and a Paduan's grinding. A republic that lived by knowing first had just been shown how to know first a little longer. They priced it on the tower in the time it takes to say so. They doubled the man's salary and fixed him to his chair for life, and called the tube a gift,

all in the same breath, the way you thank a man for a present you have decided to buy from him.

I stood in the crowd and did the only sum I was fit to do, which was the trade sum, and the trade sum came out strange. Nine years before, in a market not an hour's walk behind me as the road ran south, Rome had taken a small gray man and burned him in front of a congregation for saying, among his other insolences, that the lights up there were suns with worlds about them and the worlds perhaps had people on them. They had stopped his mouth with a rag to be sure of him. And here was a professor selling the selfsame sky over the counter to a Senate, and the Senate was paying, and nobody was building anything in the middle of the square. The difference was not in the sky. The sky had not moved. The difference was in the wrapping and the buyer. Bruno had brought his heavens to Rome as a doctrine, which is contraband, and they had burned the carrier with the cargo. Galileo brought his to Venice as a spyglass for catching Turks, which is ordnance, and they pensioned him. I had handled enough banned books by then to know what fear does to a price, but this was the first time I had seen the heavens themselves put on the scale and weighed out by the ounce, and it stayed with me.

The cardinal's factor found me a fortnight after, and he hired me by testing me first, which I have always respected as the only honest interview.

He was a factor named Lelio Bardi, and he kept the Venetian end of a business whose other end I would not see for years — a cardinal in Rome with an appetite for Eastern paper and the means to feed it. Bardi was a compact, contained article of a man, all of him drawn in close to the bone with no waste anywhere, sober in black wool that had cost more than it confessed, and his mouth was the feature you remembered, a careful pursed thing that opened on each word as if it were being spent. He wore one ring, a seal, and he wore it on the hand he wrote with, and he used it the way a carpenter uses an awl, for the work and not for the looking-at. He came to my corner of the quay on no introduction and laid a single leaf on the cask I used for a desk, vellum, close-written in a Greek hand brown with years, and asked me what I would give him for the book it came out of.

I did not give him a number. I gave it back to him after a while and told him there was no book; or rather that there was a book but it was younger than its clothes, that the leaf had been cut from something genuinely old and genuinely worthless and rewritten in a hand schooled to look a few centuries deeper than it was, and that the giveaway was not the ink, which was clever, but the skin, which was too evenly thinned — a real old leaf wears unfairly, thick where a careless monk left it and worn through where a thousand thumbs found the same corner, and this one had been pared smooth all over by somebody in a hurry to sell flatness as age. The forger had thought about the writing. He had not thought about the thumbs.

Bardi's careful mouth moved a small amount, which I came to know as the furthest he went toward pleasure. He had known the thing was false when he set it down; he had carried it about Venice for the express purpose of watching young men love it. He took it back, slid it away, and in its place laid a folded paper closed with the seal off his finger, and that paper had a hand on the inside of it I would come to know better than my own father's — a long, dry, even script, generous in the margins, a collector's hand. It was a list. Most of it ran east: Greek houses on the Mountain and in the islands, the monasteries above Trebizond, certain dealers in Constantinople named in a private shorthand, the whole tilt of it eastward, toward the failing houses and the short harvests and the wars, toward wherever a library had outlived the purse that kept it. And near the bottom, in among the patristic Greek and the Syriac, one line that sat in that company like a coin from the wrong country: *the Paduan's glass, and a clean copy of whatever he prints of the sky he is said to be turning it upon, if the price is not folly.*

So it was the cardinal who sent me to Galileo, though the cardinal never knew it and Galileo cared less. I went up to Padua in the spring of the year ten, into the brick and the student noise and the smell of a university town, which is wet stone and cheap wine and ambition gone slightly off, and I found the great man at home and selling.

He was a wide, deep-chested man running to heaviness, with a reddish beard going gray at the edges as a fire goes gray, and heavy lids over eyes that did their mocking from half-shut, so that you never had the whole of his attention and always suspected the held-back part was laughing at you.

His hands were the surprise. I had expected a scholar's hands and I got a workman's — nicked, stained, the right thumb flattened and shining where a man bears down for years on something he is grinding true. He ground his own lenses. He was, under the chair and the salary and the Latin, a handworker like me, and that did me no good at all, because it meant I respected him before I had finished deciding I did not like him, and the two opinions never afterward came apart.

The book was just out, thin, in paper still almost soft, and I had it in my hands a moment before I had it in my mind, and what my hands told me was that it had been printed in a tearing hurry — the impressions uneven, one gathering set by a tired man at night, the whole thing flung at the press the instant the writing was dry. Only a binder would have cared. But it told me something the text did not, which was that a man does not race a book to the stall like that to instruct the world; he races it because he is afraid someone will say a thing first, or because he has somewhere to be and wants the thing selling before he goes.

He named four new lights, he told me, turning the glass over in those ground-down hands while I counted his coin — four little moons going round about Jupiter where God and Aristotle had hung nothing, and he had not let them lie there nameless for the next man to claim. He had named them. He had hung four new bodies in the heavens and called them after a prince, the *Medicea Sidera*, the Medici's own stars, and he said it watching me to see whether I understood the size of the gift.

"A Senate," he said, "buys a man's hours, and pays a clerk's wage for them, and thinks it has bought the man. A prince knows better. A prince buys the name a thing is christened by, and pays for *that*, because he knows it is the only part of any of this that lasts." He set the glass down. "I have put a prince's children in the sky out of the reach of weather and pope and time, and you may believe a prince knows what such a courtesy is worth, where a Senate sees only Turkish sails." He had given the Republic a spyglass and kept the stars for a buyer who understood pricing.

The glass he would sell me, since the cardinal's silver spent as well as a prince's, but he named a figure for it I would not have given for a chest of them, and named it with the bland certainty of a man who has decided that

anything his own hands have touched is dear by contagion. I told him the cardinal's man had written *if the price is not folly*, and that I came instructed in folly. He came down a third, grumbling that a republic and a churchman between them would have a philosopher grind glass for the love of God, and that no one had ever yet costed him the years it takes to learn what to grind — and there, in the grumble, was the whole of him, the great mind and the small purse lodged in the one body and the purse doing the most of the talking. We settled. He counted my coin twice.

I bought his clean copy and his glass and his half-shut contempt, paid for the first two and got the third at no charge, and carried all three down to the water, and I wrote his sentence down that night as I have written down the sentences of greater and lesser men all my life, because the keeping of words is the only revenge a furniture-boy is ever permitted on the people who talk over him.

He went to Florence that same year. Threw the lifetime chair the Senate had just bolted him into clean over his shoulder and went to be Philosopher and Mathematician to the Grand Duke, into Tuscany, into the warm lap of a court — out from under the Republic that had sheltered him, the one government in Italy whose churches Rome could not close and whose gallows Rome could not borrow, and into a place that sat, for all its silks, in the Pope's own pocket. His Venetian friends called it folly to his face and ingratitude behind it, and a sharp-tongued friar I never met but whose books I sold remarked that the Grand Duke's table was within easy reach of the Inquisition's, which the Senate's had never been.

But you must see what pulled the other way, or the man makes no sense. Venice paid him for his hours and called him Mathematician — a word that ranked him with the clerks who kept the accounts. Florence offered him Philosopher, the word that ranked him with the men who pronounced what the world was, and offered it by the hand of a Grand Duke who had sat under him as a boy learning his sums, in the country where he was born, with no lecture-hall to fill and no boarders to feed. A republic had bought his time; a prince was buying his name, and had handed him a better one in the bargain. To a man built as he was, that did not feel like walking toward

a fire. It felt like coming home raised. The fire was mine to see, and the friar's; it was nobody's in the year ten.

They were right, and it took three-and-twenty years to come due, and when it came due I was in the room, or near enough, and the man on his knees that day had the same ground-down thumb. But that night comes much later in the telling, and I will not reach for it now.

What I did with my spring was simpler, and I am not going to dress it up for you. I took the cardinal's advance.

It was good Roman silver, counted into my hand by Bardi's careful fingers against the list and the seal, and it was the first money I had ever been paid not for binding a book or carrying a paper but for *being a certain kind of man* — a man with an eye, sent up rivers, trusted to come back with the right thing and the receipts for it. I had wanted exactly this since the morning I watched Coronaro take the larger half sitting down. And I stood on the Riva with the coin in my coat and the new sky in my chest and felt, under the satisfaction, the other thing arrive and settle in — the small cold awareness, which I did not examine and did not refuse, that the purse I had just closed my hand around belonged to a prince of the same Church that had built a fire in my father's market and swept it up by noon. Galileo had chosen his master for the brightness of the stage. I had chosen mine for the size of the purse, and the purse was Rome's, and I knew it, and I took it, and I have been taking it ever since. The body keeps these accounts, I have told you. It had opened a new ledger that morning and written my name at the head of it, in a fair round hand, on the wrong side.

Then I did what the list told me, which is the whole of what a commissioned man does, and what I had wanted so badly to be.

The years ten to fourteen I will give you in a breath, because they were the apprenticeship of the road and one road is much like another in the telling — Greek houses that sold by candlelight and denied it by day, customs men whose mood was the only tariff that mattered, a forger or two who taught me what the Padua leaf had begun to, that the source is where the danger lives and also where the lies live, exactly as Coronaro had promised from his safe chair. My eye sharpened on it. My Greek stopped being a thing I

was cheated in and started being a thing I cheated with, a little, when the cheating was owed. And every list that came north under that seal pointed me further from the Veneto and deeper toward the rising sun, until the spring the seal sent me past the Greek islands altogether, to the city on the water between two worlds, where the new sky was no news at all and the oldest books in Christendom were being weighed out by men who hated the men they sold them to. The new sky I left behind me to be tried, in its time, in Rome. I had older paper to catch, and a ship that would not wait, and I went east with the list buttoned inside my coat over the place the coin had been.

Chapter Six — The Price in Skin

We were a week of evenings into it by then, and the boy had stopped pretending he climbed the stairs for the ledger. He came up, set the coals to catch, poured for us both — he had given over testing the bottle, having proved across several nights that Lanfranchi's cellar was too dull to turn — and he arrived, as he had taken to arriving, with the night's question already loaded, which I had come to see was a printer's habit: the trade sets its letters backward and the man learns to put the last thing first.

"The Frenchman," he said. "Three nights you have dangled him. Vautier."

"I dangle him because he is worth dangling, and because you take the stairs two at a time when there is a Frenchman at the top of them." I turned my cup. "Anselme Vautier. Cardinal Richelieu's purse with a man folded up inside it. He comes later than tonight, and east of it, and I will not spend him early. I will give you only this, to keep you on the stairs. The man never once touched a manuscript with his bare hand. He wore gloves, scented ones, and he carried three grades of them, and a careful watcher could price any book in a room by which pair Vautier drew on to lift it — the good kid for what he meant to buy, the plain for what he meant to leave, and a third pair, an old split ruin he kept oiled for the purpose, that he pulled on only to handle a thing he had decided to call a forgery to the face of the man selling it."

Tommaso laughed, the short bark of a boy who has been handed more than he asked for.

"That is his whole soul in a glovebox," I said, "and you may have the rest of him when we reach the year he earned it. Tonight he is a pair of gloves. Be content."

"You are a miser with your own story."

"I am a dealer with my own story. There is a difference, and it is the difference I mean to teach you before the candle goes." I set the cup down where I could find it again. "I taught you the cheerful half of this trade in Venice. *Condemned at Rome* is the only notice that sells; the Index of forbidden books, north of the mountains, is a price-list, and a dealer who ignores it deserves to keep a stationer's shop and die solvent and forgotten.

You wrote it down and looked pleased with the arrangement of the world. I let you look pleased. You had not yet earned a fright.”

“And now I have?”

“Now you will sit still and take the back of the coin. The same word that doubles a book’s price in Venice will, carried three weeks in the wrong direction, knot a rope around the man carrying it. *Condemned at Rome* is a recommendation where Rome cannot reach you and a hanging matter where she can, and the whole of the trade is the narrow seam between the two, and you learn where the seam runs by getting opened along it.” I pushed my left sleeve back from the wrist, far enough, and let him see the old white cord of it run up the forearm and stop. “There is the receipt. Constantinople paid it. Bank the brazier and I will take you to where I bought it.”

I came up to Constantinople in the year fourteen with the seal buttoned in my coat and my Greek at last worth more than my apologies for it, and the city did to me what it does to every man who arrives by water, which is to refuse to be looked at all at once. You came round the point and there was simply too much of it — hills of houses going up into the smoke of their own fires, the great dome riding above the lot like a thing set down by something larger and forgotten, the water between thick with caiques and lighters and the slow Venetian round-ships, and the whole of it loud in five languages before you had touched a stone. I was one-and-thirty. I was lean from the road in a way I would not stay much longer, my black hair not yet giving anything back to the comb, and my hands — a binder’s hands, my father’s hands, the only inheritance that ever fed me — were by then quick enough at a strange script to make a customs man wait while I read what he could not.

My business lived across the Horn, in Pera, which is the Frankish town — for out there we are all Franks, you understand, Roman and French and Venetian alike, the one word doing for the lot of us as *the Turk* does, in our mouths, for every soul under the Sultan; the ledge of the city where the Latins keep their houses and their churches and their quarrels and the Venetian bailo keeps his table. Everything bound for Rome went out

from under that ledge. The other shore — Stamboul proper, the markets, the Greek houses, the men I bought from — was where the paper was; Pera was where it became cargo. I learned to live with one foot on each, ferried back and forth by boatmen who overcharged me in a Turkish I was still assembling out of gesture and insult and the patient corrections of a dragoman named Yakomi, who took a fee to put my offers into the language of the men I was robbing and another fee, I have no doubt, to tell them afterward exactly how I had tried to do it.

The two good years I will give you in a breath, because good years make poor telling. I learned the upstream trade and I learned it well. The houses sold by night and denied it by morning; a brotherhood down to its last winter would part with a Father it had copied and recopied for six centuries, weeping over the coin and pocketing the coin all the same; an heir who could not read a line of his uncle's hoard reckoned the whole of it at the worth of the leather it was bound in. A library breaks where the house around it is breaking; I learned the sound of a house failing, and to be in the room at the hour a long ownership ended, and to carry what spilled from it down to Pera and make it into cargo. The cardinal was pleased, and a pleased cardinal is a standing invitation to be pleased again.

The best of it came down to me out of a daughter-house, a little dependent cell of one of the Mountain's great monasteries, set inland where the harvest had failed two years running and the brothers were down to a count you could take on two hands. A man came to Pera with it wrapped in a cloth that had been a cassock, and would not open the cloth in the street. In the back of a wine-shop he opened it: a Gregory, the Theologian's orations, in a Greek hand I dated at four hundred years and the binding older than the hand had a right to wear, the boards split and recased once by someone who knew less than I did, the sewing original underneath and sound. I have told you my one gift. It is in the hands, not the head. I turned the quires and felt the centuries in the give of the spine the way you feel a horse's age in its mouth, and I knew before I had finished that this was the truest thing I had touched since Venice, and I kept my face shut over it, because the seller watched my face as narrowly as I watched his book.

He named his price before I could name mine — the first mistake, and a seller makes it only when he has never sold before, or never from hunger. “Forty ducats,” he said, as if it were a bold stroke, and then searched me for the verdict — whether he had asked for the moon or given the thing away — and could not find it, because I gave him nothing. The answer was that forty was a tenth, near enough, of what the Gregory would bring me from the cardinal’s purse, and that his fingers had not once left the cloth, pressed flat on it as though the book might bolt.

I said nothing, and the silence did my haggling for me — no agent in the trade ever worked for less — and he filled it, as the unpracticed always do, talking the price down on my own behalf — the recasing was crude, a quire was foxed, he would carry it to the very ship himself. I bought it at thirty.

I could have given him forty. I could have given him eighty and still carried a fortune down to the water, and the brothers inland would have eaten the winter on what I kept back. I gave him thirty, counted into a hand that closed on the coin before the blessing was clear of his mouth, and I told myself what I have told myself over a hundred such hands since: that a fair price is whatever a willing man will take. It is the cleanest lie the trade ever taught me. It leaves out the word hunger, and the trade runs on nothing else.

I got it out — a Greek bottom for the first leg, a Ragusan ship from Pera for the long one, papers that called it what it was not — and three seasons later Bardi’s letter came back so warm I could feel the cardinal’s pleasure through the wax. I was flush that winter, and proud, and I will own the pride to you because the next thing the year did was correct it. I had the posting by the throat. I thought the danger in the work was the work’s, an honest cost, like wet feet. I had not yet understood that the deadliest thing in my chests was the thing I had bought most legally of all.

For there was a second errand always running under the first, the cardinal’s private appetite, the one odd line that had ridden at the bottom of every list since the year ten: the new sky. He wanted the heavens, in print, whatever Christendom was saying of them, and Pera fed me that as readily as Stam-boul fed me the Fathers — the Frankish booksellers had it off the Venetian ships, fresh, the ink barely cured. I had bought, when they were nothing but desirable, a clean old uncorrected Copernicus, the Nuremberg book itself,

and beside it a little hot thing out of Naples, a Carmelite's pamphlet arguing with great courtesy that the moving earth could be squared with Scripture if one read Scripture kindly. Bought, packed, declared, and as licit as a psalter, the morning I crated them.

The news came up the sea behind them, months stale, as all news reached us — that in the spring, in Rome, the Holy Office had suspended the Nuremberg book until it should be corrected, and had not troubled to suspend the Carmelite at all but simply forbidden him, root and branch. I had it from a Dominican at the bailo's table who delivered it as a small triumph of good order, between the soup and the fish, and I sat with my face arranged for him and did, under the table, the only sum I have ever been able to do quickly, which is the price of a thing.

And the sum came out double. That is the part I need you to feel, because it is the whole of the trade in one figure. The decree had not lowered the value of those two books by a single soldo. It had doubled it — trebled the Carmelite, which now existed nowhere a careful man could be seen to sell it. The condemnation was the advertisement, exactly as I had taught you, and the same condemnation was, on this shore, a rope, exactly as I had not. I went back across the Horn that night and opened my own crates by candle and sorted my cargo by the decree, leaf from leaf, this one a Father and merely precious, this one a Carmelite and a hanging matter, my hands knowing the difference before I had the lamp near. The cardinal had sent me up the rivers of the world after the sky. The sky had turned, in a chamber in Rome he had perhaps voted in, into the most dangerous freight in my keeping, and he was warm in that chamber, and I was not.

The trouble, when it came, did not wear a Turk's face. The Sultan's men did not care a fig what the Pope of the Latins had forbidden the Latins; banned Christian books were no contraband in a city that held all our heresies in the same mild contempt. The danger was a Latin danger, and it lived in Pera, and it was a Ragusan named Marin who had carried Catholic cargo for me twice and clean, and would have carried this had the soup-side Dominican kept his triumph to himself a season longer.

Marin was a lean, sallow article with a nose broken once and set by an optimist, so that it pointed his face a few degrees off true, and he had a habit

of cracking the knuckles of one hand against the opposite palm, slow, while he reckoned what a thing was going to cost him. Ragusa is a small Catholic republic that does its enormous trade entirely on Ottoman sufferance and Roman goodwill, and a Ragusan who is found running the Copernican opinion to a cardinal — or worse, found by the wrong cardinal — does not lose a cargo. He loses the Republic, and the Republic, learning of it, loses him first to keep itself. He worked all that out faster than I have written it, the knuckles going, and named me a price to clear the chests that was not a fee but a confession that he would rather not.

I should have let it go. I want to be honest with you about why I did not, because it would flatter me to say loyalty and it was not loyalty. It was the doubled sum. A man does not abandon on a wharf a thing that has just become worth twice what he paid, not if the man is what I had spent fourteen years making myself, and so I haggled with Marin over the price of my own neck as if it were a chest of psalters, and when he saw I would not be plucked clean he made the practical man's decision, which is always the worst one. If he could neither clear the cargo safely nor be paid enough to risk it, then the cargo had to stop existing, and the Frank who owned it had to become, if anyone ever asked, a Frank he had warned and turned away.

I went down to the Ragusan's store by the water that night to take my chests out from under him before he could make them disappear, and I did not go alone, but I went too few. There was a lamp and then there was no lamp. Someone had it out, and the dark was full of more men than I had brought, and a voice I knew was telling me, almost kindly, to stand still and lose only the cargo.

I did not stand still. It was very fast.

I got an arm up — the left, across my face, the way the body throws a shutter before the mind has voted — and the blade meant for somewhere worse went into the meat of the forearm and drew along it as I turned, and the heat of it was the only clean information in the whole black room. Then my own men were in, and there was the ugly close grappling that has no shape to it and is over before you can be afraid in any useful way, and we came out into the wharf-light with two of my three chests and my arm hanging warm and the front of me black and slick to the waist.

I sat on a bollard and bound it myself, because there was no one to do it better and my hands had paired and sewn since before I could spell. They did the work while I watched them, as if they were a tradesman I had hired and was half-minded to dismiss, and the thought that came to me, idiot and exact, was that a wound is only a tear, and a tear sews the same in skin as in vellum, from the middle outward, easing the gape before you close the ends. I lost the third chest. It held the lawful freight — Greek Fathers, sound and old and merely precious — and I abandoned it in the dark, because the two I dragged clear held the Copernicus and the Carmelite, and even gut-frighted and bleeding I had grabbed by value, which tells you everything about the man I was and most of what I am.

The two banned books reached Rome. Of course they did; that is what the telling is for. They went out by a Jewish house that asked no questions a coin could not close, and word came back in the spring, in that long dry script, that his Eminence was *most particularly gratified* by the Naples item, it being now so very scarce, and would I be alert to further such. He did not ask how it had grown scarce. He did not ask what the scarcity had cost, because the scarcity was his profit and the cost was not his line of the ledger. In Constantinople the body stopped keeping my accounts in ink.

That is the first lesson the trade ever wrote on me where I could not lose the page. A throne in Rome takes fright of a book, and the fright runs out across the whole of the sea faster than any ship can carry the book itself, and where the fright lands it raises the price and where it raises the price it sharpens the knife, and the same decree pays the cardinal his rarity and pays his agent in skin, and the two payments are entered, you understand, in two different hands.

Chapter Seven — The House on the Other Bank

“I do not see how it was done,” Tommaso said.

He had spent his afternoon over his father’s accounts and come up the stairs still at war with them, and he set the coals to the brazier and the question to me in the one motion, which was his habit by then. “You have told me you were never a rich man, and you have told me with some satisfaction. A binder’s son, a clerk’s wage. And then you went out into the world and bought” — he turned a hand at the presses around us, the dark spines, the locked doors beyond — “this. Sixty years of it. With what? Whose purse crossed the sea every time you found a book worth the having?”

“No purse crossed the sea. That is the first thing to get out of your head, and the most expensive thing for a young man to learn, because he learns it from being robbed. A purse that crosses the sea is taken at the third bridge by men who can smell silver through the leather and the prayers. I never carried above what would feed me to the next house.”

“Then how was anything paid for?”

“On paper. On a name.” I let him look unsatisfied with that, because he was a printer’s son and I wanted to watch him take the insult. “I would walk into a counting-house in Aleppo, or Isfahan, or a damp room in Pera, with a letter, and against that letter a man I had never seen would weigh me out good local silver, and the silver had never been in Rome and the cardinal’s silver never left Rome, and the two sums shook hands across two thousand miles and never met. The money does not travel. Only the promise travels, and the promise travels faster and lighter than any chest, and no corsair has ever yet boarded a ship to steal a man’s word.”

“Paper.” He said it the way he sets it — a printer’s son knows to the half-ream what paper is worth, and it is not much. “You bought a library with paper. My father is owed eleven scudi on paper this very night, by men who cross the road when they see him coming.”

“Your father is owed by men who can hide in Rome, which is a city built for hiding debts in. The houses I drew on were owed by men who could not hide anywhere under heaven, because the next caravan would carry the news of a dishonored draft to every house from Venice to Agra, and every door

would shut on the defaulter in the same week, and a closed door is a dead man who has not yet been told. That is not paper. That is a man's whole standing in the world, written small enough to fold. Your father should pray to be cheated by an Armenian. He would at least be cheated by someone with something to lose."

The boy laughed, and I did not, because a man who laughs at his own remark spends it, and I have always preferred to bank mine and let the borrower carry the interest. But I let it sit between us, warm.

"The house that taught me all this," I said, "stood on the wrong bank of a river in the middle of the world. I had better take you there before the wine is gone."

I came down into Isfahan in the spring of the year seventeen, the better part of five months off the Horn, having gone overland through the Armenian country and over the passes and down by way of Tabriz with one caravan and then another, the cold of the high road still in my coat. I was four-and-thirty. The scar on my left forearm was that winter's age and no more, a white cord I kept catching on my own cuff, not yet a thing I forgot I wore. My Greek and my Turkish had carried me as far as a certain river and then gone deaf, and my Persian was a fistful of words a dragoman had beaten into me on the march, badly, so that for my first month in the richest city I had ever stood in I bought and sold like a clever child, pointing and overpaying and learning the price of my own ignorance by the abbasi.

They call it half the world. *Nesf-e jahan* — Isfahan is half the world, the Persians say, and they say it as Venice says it lives forever, which is to say as a boast that has been true long enough to stop feeling like one. I did not come to marvel. I came to appraise, which is the only honest way I have ever had of loving a place, and the appraisal was large. There was a square in it you could have set three Piazzas inside and lost them, and a king's mosque going up at one end of the square the colour of the inside of a wave, and arcades a mile deep stacked with more goods than the whole Rialto sees in a year, and over all of it a light that did to blue tile what the lagoon does to evening, which is to make a sober man distrust his own eye. A city

that meant to be looked at, built by a king who had the means to be looked at and the wit to know it was cheaper than an army, most years.

The trade I had come for lived across the river, on the south bank of the Zayanderud, over a bridge so long and so populous it was a town laid sideways on the water. New Julfa, they called it, the suburb the Shah had made for his Armenians — and *his* is the word that matters, the word I did not yet know how to hear. He had built them a handsome quarter of churches and tall houses and walled gardens, and he kept them rich because their riches were his, the silk of the whole north running through their hands and a tithe of it sticking to his, and he guarded them from his own mullahs as a farmer guards a milch cow from his own dogs. I crossed to it with a letter folded in my coat, and the letter was the only thing about me that had any standing on that bank.

The house Bardi had sent me to — named months before, in his careful close hand, as the one establishment in New Julfa a Frank could trust with the cardinal's credit and his own neck together — was the house of Khoja Sarkis, and a *khoja* among those people is a merchant grown so large the word for merchant will no longer cover him. It stood off a court behind a plain street door, which is how money dresses when it has nothing to prove, and inside the door it stopped pretending — a court with a tank of water in it green and still, rooms opening off it deep and cool and smelling of musk and dust and ledgers, and everywhere the particular hush of a place where large sums are at rest and would prefer not to be disturbed.

Khoja Sarkis received me himself, which I took, in my ignorance, for an honour done to me, and which was in fact the courtesy a great house pays automatically to a letter it has not yet decided about. He was a broad, slow, comfortable old man with a grey beard spread over his chest like a bib and a host's wide easy manner, and he sat me down and fed me and asked — in the supple, accentless Italian of a house that had been banking Franks since before I was born — after the roads and the war in the west and the health of cardinals he named more accurately than I could, and poured a wine out of his own country better than anything Lanfranchi has ever let me steal, and through the whole of it his eyes did sums on me that his mouth was much too well-mannered to mention. It was a strange ease, after five weeks

gone deaf and clumsy in Persian, to sit in a room where my own tongue was the currency, and it was the house's, not the man's: they had been trading into Venice and Rome for three generations, and they met a Frank in his own language as a matter of business, as I had learned to meet a customs man in his. I had done my first weeks' changing at the public booths in the bazaar — a newcomer not yet certain he meant to stay, and confident enough in his own reckoning to keep his money in his own hands a while longer rather than trust it to a house of strangers. A man gives his banking to a house only once he means to stay, and I had not yet owned to myself that I did. When at last I came to my business — that I held the cardinal's credit and wished to draw on it, to bank what I cleared, to ship for Rome through the house's hands — he spread those hands wide and smiled and said the thing I have never forgotten, because it was the first true thing said to me in Isfahan.

"All that," he said, "my daughter keeps. I spend. She knows what I have spent." And he turned his grey head toward the doorway of the counting-room, where a woman had been standing in the cool the whole while, listening to every word and weighing it, and waiting to be wanted.

She came forward when her father named her and not a step before. She was tall, and built strongly through the shoulder in a way that had nothing soft to apologize for, and she had a wide-set, level pair of eyes that took the measure of a stranger as plainly as a customs man takes the measure of a chest, and her hands — I noticed her hands, because I am my father's son and notice hands before I notice faces — were stained brown to the wrist and into the creases of the knuckles, the deep walnut brown of a copyist's ink that no washing takes out, the mark of a woman who not only kept the books but made them. She wore the brown like a tradesman's apron, which is what it was. Marjan, her father called her. She inclined her head the precise amount my letter had earned and not a hair more, and I made the error I had been making since the passes, which was to take a brisk woman for a cold one, and a cold one for a simple one.

"You have the cardinal's letters of credit," she said. Not a question. "And you have been in the city a month."

"Five weeks."

“Then you have been changing his money in the great bazaar, at the booths by the gold-smiths, with a *sarraf* who weighs you out the local silver against the cardinal’s letters and tells you what Rome is worth that morning.” She named it back to me flat, as the apothecary names your complaint before he sells you the cure. “Show me your account of it. What you have changed, and what you took for it.”

I had the account. I was proud of the account. I had kept it as my father kept his stitches, close and clean, and I laid it on the table between us thinking to be admired for it, and she read it the way I read a binding — fast, from the inside, and without any of the pleasure the maker had hoped to provide.

“Here,” she said, and her brown forefinger went down the column and stopped. “And here. And every line under it.” She did not raise her voice; she did not need to, having found the body before the family had finished hoping it was asleep. “The rate you were given is the rate we give a Frank who is in the city a month and proud of his arithmetic. It is short — not by theft, by custom, which is worse, because you cannot complain of it. Three in the hundred, near enough, on the change. And then your *sarraf* charged you again to remit to Rome what you had only just turned into coin, when the house could have drawn the draft direct against the cardinal’s name and never touched the silver at all. You have paid twice to move money that should not have moved once.” She took up a reed pen, dipped it, and did in the margin of my clean account, in a hand smaller and surer than mine, the sum I had thought I had already done. It came out a long way short of the margin I had been carrying home to bed each night. “There is your season,” she said, and turned the paper back to face me. “Most of it is in the bazaar, in other men’s strongboxes, where you put it.”

I have been out-bid in my life, and out-waited, and once or twice out-fought, and a man learns to wear all of those. I had never until that afternoon been out-counted, on the one ground I had always believed was mine, by anyone, and the discovery was cold and clarifying, like the blade in Pera had been cold and clarifying, and taught the same lesson, which is that the thing you were sure of is the thing that opens you. I did not argue. Only a fool argues with the proof that his own pocket has been picked, and I have made a long living off that fool, and I was not going to become him at a table in Julfa.

I looked at her small certain figures next to my large hopeful ones, and I recalibrated the whole of my opinion of the posting and the house and the woman in the time it took the ink to dry.

“How would you have changed it?” I asked her, which was the first intelligent thing I had said in the room, and we both knew it.

Her shoulders came down a little — not warmth, she was a season off warmth, but the small private satisfaction of a craftsman asked at last about the craft. She told me. She told me about the houses and their drafts and the rates they kept among themselves and the rate they showed the world, about which money to hold and which to move and which season moved it cheapest, about the silk that was the blood of all of it and the king who let the blood for his own profit, and she told me fast and dry and complete, as I had once heard Coronaro tell it from his chair, except that Coronaro had been selling me a life of sitting safe and she was selling me nothing at all. She was simply unable to watch a thing be done badly that she knew how to do well. I have the same affliction. It is the nearest thing to virtue either of us ever owned.

“I go where houses fall,” I said, somewhere in it — reaching, I will admit, to put back on the table some coin of my own, some proof I was not merely the Frank who could not change his money. “That is my whole trade. A library never leaves the shelf while the family that loves it can still feed itself. I go where the feeding has stopped. I am where things end.”

She did not look up from the ledger she had begun to enter me into, fair and permanent, in that walnut hand.

“I know the trade from your end and from the other,” she said. “You wait for a house to fall. I am sitting in one a king knocked down on purpose.” She let the pen rest. “Julfa — the old Julfa, on the Araxes, where I was born — was a town of merchants and weavers and nothing the Shah could not buy twice over, except that they knew the silk and he wanted the silk in his own hand. So he burned the town behind us and carried the whole of it east, a thousand miles, the rich in litters and the rest on their feet, and set us down on this bank where he could see our roofs from his palace and tax our prayers. We did not fall. We were felled, and replanted, and made

to flower for the gardener. It is a better trade than yours, in one way only. You arrive after. We are the books." She dipped the pen again. "Now. Shall I keep your accounts, or will you go on enriching the gold-smiths?"

I did not answer at once, because it was not a thing to answer quickly if I was paying attention, and I had begun, against my long habit, to pay attention. I had spent seventeen years learning to stand in the doorway at the hour a long ownership ended and feel nothing but the price of what spilled out. I had built a whole man on that talent and was proud of him. And here, entering my season into a stranger's book with brown fingers, was the thing that spilled — carried out of a burning town as a child for reasons of policy, counted and resettled and made to pay, and come out the far side not broken and not soft but exact, keeping the accounts of the very arrangement that had moved her, because the accounts were the one thing in the world a king could not take from those who understood them. I had met clever people. I had met, that afternoon, the first person to see the machine I lived inside from the inside of its other half, unafraid of it, with no wish to pretend it was anything but what it was.

"Keep them," I said.

So the house of Khoja Sarkis became my harbour in half the world, and Marjan kept my accounts, and kept them better than I could have kept them with both eyes and a clear conscience, and for that spring at least the keeping was the whole of it. I will not pretend to you, who are not a fool and have a sweetheart in the Parione you think I have not noticed, that I crossed that bridge each morning only for the rate of exchange. But it was the rate of exchange we spoke of, week on week, and the drafts, and the safe season for shipping, and which monk and which heir and which failing library out on the Persian roads was worth a journey — and the speaking of those things plainly, and being answered as plainly, and usually rightly, was a pleasure I had not known I had been doing without. I had spent my life giving sellers nothing in my face to price. Across her table I did not have to. She had already read me, in an afternoon, down to the short rate I had been too proud to question, and there is a freedom in being seen that early and that completely, by eyes that mean you no harm with the seeing.

It is nearly the whole of what people mean, I think, when they say a thing they are too careful to say in Julfa or in Rome.

The seal would send me out again soon enough; there was a philosopher down the Qom road the cardinal wanted, of whom I will tell you when the candle is younger. But that was a journey for the dry season, and the spring was for the city and the house and the long apprenticeship in a woman's arithmetic, and I was in no hurry at all to learn the road out of a place it had taken me five months and my whole opinion of myself to arrive in.